A Practical Primer on European Electoral Systems

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12 October 2026

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1 What This Covers

Ten European national electoral systems: how each converts votes into seats, how seats translate into governments, and how the design of each system shapes political outcomes in practice. The primer includes comparative analysis, worked numerical examples, and a framework for evaluating coalition risk.

Verified against primary sources for sections 1–10; unverified claims are flagged inline.

Review date: 12 October 2026. Election examples are dated historical outcomes, not live cabinet or parliamentary membership trackers. Denmark and Sweden's examples include their 2026 elections; government formation is discussed only where supported by the cited record.

2 What This Is Not

This is not a complete history of electoral-system evolution, and it makes no argument for which system is best. It is not a guide to voting as a citizen in any particular country. The EU Parliament election process is used as contextual scaffolding, but this primer is about domestic systems, not the EU legislature itself.

European voting systems are different ways of solving the same problem: turning votes into seats and seats into governments. They optimise for different priorities, including proportional fairness, local MP accountability, party control, and coalition stability. That is why systems that look similar on paper can produce very different political outcomes.

In this primer, an electoral system means the rules that convert votes into seats. A constitutional system means the rules that allocate executive authority and parliamentary accountability. A political outcome means the government, coalition, or bargaining pattern produced after those rules interact with parties, geography, and political choices. The terms are related, but they are not interchangeable.

If you want the short version, the real argument underneath almost every European system is this: how much should the system reward a clear winner, and how much should it try to mirror the actual shape of the vote? Once you see that trade-off, the rest of the map gets easier to read.

3 Foundational Concepts

3.1 The Core Electoral Trade-Off

There are really four things that electoral systems keep juggling:

1. Proportionality: does 30 percent of the vote get roughly 30 percent of the seats?
2. Local accountability: do voters get a specific person they can blame, praise, or lobby?
3. Party control: does the party leadership decide who gets in, or do voters have real influence over candidates?

4. Stability: does the system tend to produce single-party governments, or does it push parties into coalitions and bargaining?

No system nails all four. Every design picks a flavour of trade-off. The UK, Germany, Ireland, Spain, Italy, the Netherlands, Denmark, and Sweden have parliamentary systems. France and Romania are **semi-presidential**: a directly elected president shares executive authority with a prime minister and a government accountable to parliament. That constitutional distinction is separate from the electoral formula: France uses two-round legislative contests, while Romania uses list PR. France's constitutional framework and Romania's Constitution, Articles 81, 103, and 109 establish the respective executive arrangements.

3.2 How the EU Layer Fits Above National Elections

One reason European politics can feel confusing is that there are two interacting levels of democratic authority:

1. National constitutional systems (who forms the government in each state).
2. EU institutions (where member states and EU-level representatives co-legislate).

Those levels are linked but not identical. You do not vote in one election and get one single chain of command all the way up.

3.2.1 The Core EU Institutions in Plain English

1. European Council: Heads of state or government from each member state. Sets strategic direction.
2. Council of the European Union (Council of Ministers): National ministers by policy area. Co-legislates with Parliament.
3. European Parliament: Directly elected by EU citizens. Co-legislates with the Council.
4. European Commission: Proposes legislation, enforces EU law, manages implementation.
5. Court of Justice of the European Union (CJEU): Final interpreter of EU law.

3.2.2 What National Elections Actually Change at EU Level

National elections matter because they decide who runs each member state government. Those governments then sit in the European Council and send ministers to the Council of the EU. So even if an election is "national", it shifts bargaining power inside EU lawmaking.

At the same time, European Parliament elections run on their own cycle and party groups. That creates a dual-democratic system:

1. National executive legitimacy channel.
2. Transnational parliamentary legitimacy channel.

3.2.3 Why This Matters for Analysis

If you only model national seat arithmetic, you miss part of the policy pipeline. Serious political-risk analysis in Europe usually needs both:

1. Domestic government-formation logic.
2. EU coalition and qualified-majority dynamics.

That is the frame for the country sections below: each electoral system is explained together with the constitutional structure it feeds into.

3.2.4 A Practical EU Policy-Flow Walkthrough

The most useful way to see the EU layer is as a chain of linked political veto points rather than one single election result.

Here is a realistic flow using an energy-transition file as an example.

1. A national election changes government in a large member state.
2. The incoming cabinet changes negotiating instructions for its energy minister and finance minister.
3. That shift immediately affects Council bargaining, because those ministers now represent different red lines on cost-sharing, timelines, or exemptions.
4. In parallel, MEPs from that country join their European Parliament groups and influence committee positions, amendments, and final voting discipline.
5. The Commission proposal is still the legal starting point, but practical text changes happen through rapporteur work, shadow negotiations, and Council working groups.
6. Trilogue bargaining then compresses the politically possible overlap between Parliament and Council.
7. Final legal text returns to national implementation, where domestic coalition politics again determines execution speed and enforcement strictness.

For analysis, this creates a simple rule: do not treat a national election as just a domestic event. It often changes both Council arithmetic and the parliamentary negotiation environment at EU level.

The forecasting implication is concrete. If two or three medium-to-large member states all move towards similar fiscal or industrial-policy preferences, the odds of EU-level compromise

rise. If they move in opposite directions, files stall, dilute, or split into partial deals.

3.2.5 Two End-to-End EU Legislative Pathway Examples

The cleanest way to operationalize this is to map a full file lifecycle. Below are two compact pathways analysts can reuse.

3.2.5.1 Pathway A: Carbon Border Adjustment Mechanism Style File

1. Commission drafting: DG-level design sets scope, reporting obligations, and timeline assumptions.
2. Parliament first pass: committee work pushes amendments on sector coverage, transition timing, and enforcement burden.
3. Council position: member-state governments split over competitiveness risk, exemptions, and implementation cost.
4. Trilogue compression: Parliament and Council trade breadth for feasibility, often tightening compliance but phasing in sanctions.
5. Formal adoption: final legal text reflects both climate ambition and industrial policy constraints.
6. National execution: customs authorities, environment ministries, and finance ministries implement with uneven administrative speed.

Analytical takeaway: changes in national governing coalitions can materially shift Council red lines even when Parliament party-group balance is stable.

3.2.5.2 Pathway B: Electricity Market Reform Style File

1. Trigger event: energy-price shock creates political urgency.
2. Commission package: proposal balances market design stability with consumer-protection pressure.
3. Council fault lines: some states prioritise fiscal shielding and contracts-for-difference scale; others prioritise market discipline and cross-border neutrality.
4. Parliament bargaining: groups align around affordability messaging but diverge on intervention depth.
5. Trilogue outcome: compromise text often includes broad framework language with delegated detail left to implementation stages.
6. Domestic political return loop: national governments claim credit or assign blame, feeding back into subsequent election campaigns.

Analytical takeaway: emergency-driven files can pass quickly, but downstream implementation risk rises when compromise language is politically broad and technically thin.

3.3 The Cleanest Mental Model

The easiest way to think about these systems is on a spectrum.

At one end, you have pure winner-takes-all systems. One district, one winner, everyone else goes home annoyed. That is the UK.

Then you get systems that soften the blow by adding a second round or a ranked ballot. France does that with a runoff, and Ireland does it with transfers.

Then you get proportional systems, where the goal is not to manufacture a fake majority but to mirror the vote more faithfully. Spain, the Netherlands, Denmark, Sweden, and Romania live somewhere on that terrain, though each one does it differently.

Finally, you get hybrid systems like Germany and Italy, which try to mix local representation with proportional outcomes. Germany does it in a very deliberate compensatory way. Italy does it more as a side-by-side blend of district races and list seats.

That is the whole game. Everything else is detail.

4 The 10 Electoral Systems

4.1 The United Kingdom: First-Past-the-Post

The UK is the simplest system in this group, and simplicity is both its strength and its curse.

The country is split into 650 constituencies, and each constituency elects one MP. You get one vote. The candidate with the most votes wins. That is it. No transfers. No second round. No topping up. No proportional correction later.

That means the system is incredibly good at producing a clear local winner. You know exactly who your MP is, and that MP knows exactly which patch of turf they are supposed to represent. But the national result can be wildly disproportional.

Toy example:

Candidate	Votes
Alice	36%
Bob	34%

Candidate	Votes
Charlie	20%
Dana	10%

Alice wins, even though 64 percent of voters picked someone else.

That is the central FPTP trade-off. It is clean and decisive, but it wastes many votes and can punish parties whose support is spread thinly across the country.

The political effect is familiar: fewer parties, more tactical voting, and governments that often have a working majority without needing a coalition.

4.2 France: Two-Round Voting

France is still winner-takes-all in spirit, but it adds a second round so that the final winner usually has broader support.

France's semi-presidential system has two separate electoral mandates. The presidential election chooses the head of state; legislative elections choose the 577-member National Assembly. The president appoints the prime minister, but the government can be brought down by the Assembly. A presidential win therefore does not guarantee a legislative majority or a cabinet that can survive a censure vote.

In presidential elections, if nobody gets an outright majority in round one, the top two go to a runoff. In legislative elections, the rule is a bit looser: candidates can qualify for round two if they clear a threshold tied to registered voters, which means local races can sometimes become three-way or even four-way contests before some candidates withdraw.

That makes France feel less brutal than the UK system. You can vote sincerely in round one, then use round two to settle the real fight. In practice, round two often becomes a referendum on who should be blocked rather than a pure love letter to one candidate.

Toy example:

Round 1:

Candidate	Votes
Left	31%
Centre	24%
Hard Right	29%

Candidate	Votes
Other	16%

Nobody wins outright, so the top two or three relevant contenders move forward, depending on the election type. In legislative races, whether the third candidate here (Centre, at 24%) actually qualifies for round two depends on turnout, since the threshold is measured against registered voters rather than votes cast, not against the other candidates' totals. Then the losing camps may negotiate, withdraw, or ask their supporters to consolidate around one side.

That is why French elections can get very political between rounds: the system creates a bargaining window, not just a counting process.

The presidential runoff guarantees a majority of valid votes for the winner. A legislative second round can be won by plurality in a race with three or more candidates. Both give voters a chance to regroup after the first pass; neither guarantees proportional seats or a governing majority in the Assembly.

4.3 Ireland: STV, or Ranked Choice With Actual Teeth

Ireland is where the ballot gets more elegant and more complicated at the same time.

Voters rank candidates: 1, 2, 3, and so on. Seats are won in multi-member constituencies using the Droop quota, which is roughly the minimum vote share needed to guarantee a seat in a district with several seats. If a candidate has surplus votes, those votes transfer. If nobody has enough, the lowest candidate gets eliminated and their ballots transfer.

This is one of the nicest systems to explain with an example because it feels almost intuitive once you watch the count move.

Toy example in a 3-seat district with 10,000 valid votes:

Quota = (10,000 / (3 + 1)) + 1 = 2,501

Candidate	First prefs
Alice	4,000
Bob	2,000
Charlie	1,800
Dana	1,400

Candidate	First prefs
Eve	800

Alice gets elected immediately and her surplus gets transferred. If Bob benefits, he may cross the quota next. If not, the bottom candidates are knocked out one by one until three seats are filled.

The nice part is that voters can support people, not just logos. They can rank candidates from the same party or across parties, which increases voter agency.

The trade-off is count complexity. STV is proportional, but it is not neat. It can take time, especially with paper ballots and transfers that need careful handling.

4.4 Germany: Mixed-Member Proportional

Germany is probably the cleanest example of a system that tries to have both a local MP and a fair overall party result.

Voters get two votes. One is for a local constituency candidate. The other is for a party. The party vote is the important one because it determines how many seats the party deserves overall. Local winners are then added in, and list seats are used to bring each party up to its proportional share.

That is the key German idea: the seat total follows the party vote, not the district races.

Toy example:

Party	Party vote	Entitled seats
A	40%	40
B	30%	30
C	30%	30

In a 100-seat chamber, now imagine Party A wins 45 local districts while Party B wins 10 and Party C wins 5. Under older versions of the system, the parliament would grow to accommodate the overhang. Under the newer German rules, the seat total is capped and some constituency winners from the overrepresented party may not be seated.

Still, the logic is consistent: Germany wants the final parliament to match the party vote as closely as possible without completely abandoning local districts.

This is why Germany is often treated as the gold standard for proportional mixed systems.

4.5 Italy: Rosatellum, the Hybrid That Is Not Fully Compensatory

Italy's current system is a mixed setup, but it is not the same kind of balance as Germany's.

Roughly speaking, some seats are won in single-member districts and the rest are filled from party lists. The key point is that the two parts do not fully compensate each other the way German MMP does. So it is mixed, but not truly proportional in the clean compensatory sense.

Italy also uses thresholds, which helps keep the legislature from fragmenting too far, and it strongly encourages pre-election alliances. In plain English: if you are a serious party in Italy, you usually need friends.

This system tends to reward coalitions, tactical coordination, and compromise before the vote, while still allowing post-election instability when alliances are necessity-driven.

The easiest way to think about Italy is: it tries to combine local races and proportional lists, but the marriage is looser and less elegant than Germany's.

4.6 Spain: Closed-List PR With D'Hondt

Spain is proportional, but not in a perfectly smooth way.

Voters pick a party list, not individual candidates. The parties control the ranking. Seats are allocated by province, and the D'Hondt method slightly favours larger parties. Small provinces also get minimum seat guarantees, which gives rural areas extra weight and makes the overall system less proportional than a simple nationwide PR design.

Toy example in a 5-seat province:

Party	Votes
A	100,000
B	75,000
C	45,000
D	15,000

Using D'Hondt, the seats might go 2, 2, 1, 0. That is proportional-ish, but not perfectly so, and in a smaller district the weaker parties can be squeezed out completely.

Spain is useful because it shows that PR is not automatically ultra-fair. District size and formula design can quietly reshape outcomes.

4.7 The Netherlands: The Purest Big-Tent Party System in This Set

The Netherlands is one of the closest things Europe has to a national-scale party-list PR machine.

The whole country is effectively one constituency for the House of Representatives. Voters cast a vote for a party list or a specific candidate on that list. Seats are allocated nationally. The natural threshold is tiny because there are 150 seats, so one seat is roughly 0.67 percent of the vote.

That means very small parties can get in, and political fragmentation is normal. Coalitions are not an accident in the Netherlands. They are the basic operating system.

One useful detail is that voters are not completely locked out of candidate choice. It is a semi-open, or flexible-list, system: a candidate needs preference votes exceeding roughly a quarter of the electoral quota to jump the list order, and in practice list order still decides the vast majority of seats. The party still controls the overall list structure, but voters have more say than in a closed-list system like Spain.

Toy example:

Party	Vote share	Seats in a 150-seat chamber
A	30%	45
B	20%	30
C	15%	23
D	10%	15
E	5%	7-8

That is the basic Dutch story: lots of parties, lots of bargaining, lots of proportionality, and very little room for manufactured majorities.

In one sentence: Dutch voters are effectively allocating national political shares rather than choosing local winners.

4.8 Denmark: Proportional Representation With a Top-Up Safety Net

Denmark is a great example of a system that looks proportional, feels proportional, and still has enough moving parts to keep political scientists busy.

The Folketing has 179 seats, but the key design is the split between constituency seats and levelling seats. Voters usually get one vote. That vote helps elect a candidate in a district and also feeds the overall proportional allocation. Levelling seats then correct for distortions so the national result lines up with the vote.

Denmark also uses thresholds, but they are not a blunt wall that shuts everyone out. Parties can qualify through different routes, including winning a constituency seat or clearing a national vote threshold.

Why this matters: Denmark combines high proportionality with a local district feel, sitting between Dutch national PR and Ireland's candidate-centred model.

Toy example:

Suppose Party A does very well in a few districts but not as well nationally. The district seats may temporarily overstate its strength. Then the levelling seats are used to pull the final seat total back towards its real vote share.

That is the whole point of the system: local results first, proportional correction afterwards.

4.9 Sweden: Proportional, Open-List, and Slightly More Candidate-Friendly

Sweden uses list PR with a modified Sainte-Laguë method, multi-member districts, and adjustment seats. It is proportional, but not mechanically identical to Denmark or the Netherlands.

The ballot is more open than in Spain. Voters can cast a personal vote for a candidate, and if that candidate clears the preference threshold, they can jump the list order. So the party still matters, but voters are not completely stuck with the party leadership's preferred ranking.

There is also a national threshold, plus a constituency threshold route in some cases. The result is usually a fairly proportional parliament with a manageable number of parties, plus a political culture that is comfortable with minority governments and case-by-case support.

Toy example:

Party	Vote share	Seat share
A	30%	about 30%
B	20%	about 20%
C	10%	about 10%

The exact seat numbers will move around because of district allocation and adjustment seats, but that is the overall point: the system tries very hard to make votes and seats line up.

Sweden is more proportional than France or the UK, more open than Spain, and more party-list-driven than Ireland.

4.10 Romania: Closed-List PR With Thresholds and a Very Political Reality

As of October 2026, Romania uses closed-list proportional representation for its parliament. Parties submit lists, voters choose a list, and seats are allocated with thresholds that weed out the smallest parties.

This parliamentary ballot sits within a semi-presidential constitution. Voters elect the president separately; the president designates a prime-ministerial candidate after consultations, and the proposed government needs parliament's confidence. The government is politically accountable to parliament. A presidential result and a parliamentary list result therefore answer different questions about who can govern.

The important thing here is that Romania gives you a very classic list-PR shape, but with enough thresholds and district structure to keep things from fragmenting completely. National minorities also get special treatment in the system, which is a reminder that electoral design is often doing double duty: it is not just about arithmetic, it is also about political inclusion.

Toy example:

Party	Vote share
A	22%
B	18%
C	13%
D	12%
Others	below threshold

The parties above the threshold convert votes into seats through the list formula. Parties below the threshold get nothing, which is why thresholds matter so much in PR systems. They are the difference between a parliament with a long tail of tiny parties and a parliament that is merely crowded.

Romania shows that PR does not automatically mean open candidate choice or endless fragmentation. Closed lists and thresholds can make PR feel centralised and party-driven.

5 Comparative Lenses

5.1 Ten Mini Case Studies: How Votes Became Governments

These are compact snapshots of specified election cycles, reviewed on 7 October 2026. Seat counts refer to the election outcome, before subsequent vacancies or changes of party. They illustrate translation logic; they do not establish that an electoral formula alone caused the eventual coalition choice.

5.1.1 United Kingdom

In the 2024 general election, Labour converted a vote share in the low-to-mid 30s (33.7 percent) into a very large Commons majority. Under FPTP, constituency efficiency mattered more than proportional vote-seat matching. Governing consequence: high legislative capacity early in the term, despite a sizable national vote-seat gap.

5.1.2 France

The legislative elections of 30 June and 7 July 2024 produced no absolute majority in the 577-seat Assembly: 289 seats were needed. The official electoral labels gave Union of the Left 178 seats, Ensemble 150, and National Rally 125; these labels differ from some media bloc totals and from the parliamentary groups formed later. Between-round withdrawals helped change local contests without creating a governing majority. Governing consequence: the president's power to appoint a prime minister could not supply the Assembly support needed for durable government. Sources: Interior Ministry final results and IPU election record.

5.1.3 Ireland

Ireland's November 2024 election again delivered a fragmented Dail: Fianna Fail took 48 seats and Fine Gael 38, but their combined first-preference vote share barely cleared 40 percent (21.9 and 20.8 percent respectively), with Sinn Fein a close third at 39 seats on 19 percent. STV translated that fragmented preference vote into a broad multiparty chamber with strong local-candidate dynamics, and no single party could govern alone. Governing consequence: the same Fianna Fail-Fine Gael arrangement that governed the outgoing Dail reassembled with independents (this time without the Greens), and coalition construction

again took nearly two months, with Micheal Martin returning as Taoiseach in January 2025. Coalition construction remains the core executive task under STV, not a postscript.

5.1.4 Germany

Germany's 23 February 2025 election, following the collapse of the SPD-Greens-FDP "traffic light" coalition, shows proportionality and political exclusions working together. The FDP's 4.3 percent missed the 5 percent threshold; CDU/CSU won 28.5 percent and 208 seats, AfD 20.8 percent and 152, and SPD 120 seats in the capped 630-seat Bundestag. CDU/CSU and SPD together had 328 seats, above the 316 needed for a majority. That coalition was a political choice, not a mathematical necessity: CDU/CSU and AfD also had a numerical majority, but cooperation with AfD was excluded by CDU/CSU. Merz became chancellor on 6 May 2025, after the coalition agreement in April. Governing consequence: thresholds and the seat cap shaped the chamber, while parties' willingness to cooperate determined which majority became a government. Sources: Federal Returning Officer's final result and Bundestag chancellor election.

The German coalition discussion also draws on CDU's explicit pre-election rejection of cooperation with AfD. This party statement documents a political constraint, not an electoral rule.

5.1.5 Italy

In 2022, a coherent pre-election centre-right bloc converted coalition coordination into a parliamentary majority. The mixed Rosatellum structure rewarded alliance discipline in single-member districts while list votes reinforced bloc advantage. Governing consequence: stronger initial executive control than Italy's fragmented party map might suggest.

5.1.6 Spain

The 2023 election produced no simple winner-takes-government outcome. Closed-list PR with provincial districts and regional-party leverage made investiture arithmetic hinge on post-election agreements. Governing consequence: cabinet durability became tied to ongoing support management rather than one-off coalition contracting.

5.1.7 Netherlands

The 29 October 2025 Dutch election followed the collapse of the Schoof coalition, in which PVV was the largest party. D66 and PVV each won 26 of 150 seats, but D66 had more votes: a seat tie is not a vote tie. The D66-VVD-CDA government under Rob Jetten was sworn

in on 23 February 2026 with 66 seats, short of the 76 required for a majority. Governing consequence: proportional representation preserved a fragmented chamber, and the resulting minority cabinet needed support beyond its own parties. Winning the most votes did not itself supply a governing majority. Sources: Kiesraad's final election record and government's inauguration record.

5.1.8 Denmark

In the 24 March 2026 election, Socialdemokratiet won 21.8 percent of votes and 38 of the 175 seats allocated in Denmark proper. SF won 20 seats, Venstre 18, and Moderaterne 14. The outgoing Socialdemokratiet-Venstre-Moderaterne combination thus held only 70 of those seats; the Folketing also includes four separately elected North Atlantic seats, for 179 in total. Governing consequence: PR with compensatory seats preserved broad representation but did not reproduce the outgoing coalition's majority. This is election arithmetic, not a claim about the eventual cabinet or its external support. Source: official Statistics Denmark election tables, Tables 10 and 12.

5.1.9 Sweden

Sweden's 13 September 2026 election gave Socialdemokraterna 28.02 percent and 99 of 349 seats, Moderaterna 70, and Sverigedemokraterna 62. Vänsterpartiet, Centerpartiet, Kristdemokraterna, Miljöpartiet, and Liberalerna also won seats. The four parties supporting the outgoing government arrangement — Moderaterna, Sverigedemokraterna, Kristdemokraterna, and Liberalerna — totalled 173 seats; the other four totalled 176. That arithmetic does not itself prove a new coalition agreement. Governing consequence: list PR with preference votes produced a closely divided multiparty chamber; cabinet formation still depended on party negotiations and parliamentary confidence rules. Source: Swedish Election Authority's final 2026 result.

5.1.10 Romania

Romania's 1 December 2024 parliamentary election gave PSD about 22 percent of the Chamber of Deputies vote and 86 of the 331 seats at that election. Seven parties won ordinary list seats, alongside 19 minority representatives; no party held a majority. The government formed after the election brought together PSD, PNL, and UDMR, with support from the minority group. Governing consequence: thresholds reduced the field without eliminating coalition bargaining; the separately elected presidency did not replace the need for parliamentary support. These are the 2024 election and formation figures, not the current composition of a later cabinet. Sources: IPU's parliament-supplied seat record and Radio România's

report of the electoral authority's completed count.

5.2 Vote-To-Seat Snapshot Table (Illustrative, Rounded)

The table below is intentionally approximate and decision-oriented. It is designed to anchor pattern recognition, not replace official electoral returns.

Country	Election cycle	Leading party / bloc vote share	Seat outcome at that election	System translation pattern
UK	2024	low-to-mid 30s	large absolute Commons majority	Strong winner bonus under FPTP
France	2024 legislative	no bloc majority vote	fragmented Assembly	Two-round filtering with strategic withdrawals
Ireland	2024	leading parties in low-mid 20s	no single-party majority	STV spreads representation across multiple parties
Germany	2025	CDU/CSU 28.5%	208/630; with SPD 328	Proportionality shapes arithmetic; political exclusions shape coalition choice
Italy	2022	winning coalition in low-mid 40s combined	solid parliamentary majority	Mixed system rewards pre-election bloc coordination

Country	Election cycle	Leading party / bloc vote share	Seat outcome at that election	System translation pattern
Spain	2023	largest party low-30s	no governing majority alone	Provincial PR plus regional pivots shape investiture math
Netherlands	2025	D66 narrowly ahead of PVV, both about 17%	26/150 each; D66-VVD-CDA total 66	Seat tie differs from vote tie; minority coalition needs outside support
Denmark	2026	Socialdemokratiet 21.8% (Denmark proper)	38/175; former three-party combination 70	Compensatory PR preserves representation without a coalition majority
Sweden	2026	Socialdemokraterna 28.02%	99/349; outgoing support parties total 173	Party representation and support-bloc arithmetic are separate
Romania	2024 parliamentary	PSD about 22% (Chamber vote)	86/331 at election	Closed-list PR with thresholds still requires coalition bargaining

Use this table as a quick conversion lens: when vote concentration is modest but seat concentration is high, the system is usually adding a governability bonus; when both remain fragmented, coalition negotiation is the real executive-selection mechanism.

5.3 Comparative Summary

5.3.1 At a Glance

The table compares the ten systems across ballot design, candidate control, proportionality, and local representation.

Country	Basic style	Voter picks	Who controls candidates	Proportionality	Local link
UK	FPTP	One candidate	Very strong local-party focus	Low	Very strong
France	Two-round	One candidate	Strong party and candidate control	Medium	Strong
Ireland	STV	Ranked candidates	Weakest party control of this group	High	Strong-ish
Germany	MMP	Candidate + party	Mixed	High	Strong
Italy	Hybrid mixed	Usually one ballot	Party-controlled lists plus district races	Medium	Medium
Spain	Closed-list PR	One party	Very strong party control	Medium-high, but district-limited	Medium
Netherlands	Open-list PR	Party or candidate on list	Party-controlled but with candidate preference	Very high	Weak
Denmark	PR with levelling seats	Usually one vote	Moderate party control	Very high	Medium

Country	Basic style	Voter picks	Who controls candidates	Proportionality	Local link
Sweden	Open-list PR	Party or candidate on list	Moderate party control	Very high	Medium
Romania	Closed-list PR	Party list	Very strong party control	Medium-high	Medium

5.3.2 What These Systems Feel Like in Practice

These systems differ less in democratic legitimacy than in political texture.

The UK and France emphasise decisive winner selection, but by different methods: plurality versus two-round consolidation.

Ireland emphasises voter choice among candidates, Germany engineered proportional correction, and Italy coalition-first bloc strategy.

Spain and Romania are more party-list-driven, while the Netherlands, Denmark, and Sweden combine strong proportionality with different balances of fragmentation, correction, and voter influence over candidates.

5.3.3 The Trade-Offs, Plain English

If you want a super blunt version:

1. FPTP gives you clarity, but it lies about how many people actually supported each side.
2. Runoffs soften the winner-takes-all problem, but they still do not make the result proportional.
3. STV gives voters a lot of choice, but the count is harder to follow.
4. MMP tries to have both local MPs and proportional results, but the machinery gets complicated fast.
5. Closed-list PR makes seat allocation clean, but it gives parties a lot of control.
6. Open-list PR gives voters more say, but it still keeps party logic at the centre.
7. Levelling seats and adjustment seats are the system's way of saying, "Yes, that district result was a bit weird, let's fix it."

That last idea is really the modern European theme. Very few systems are satisfied with pure winner-takes-all anymore. Even when they are not perfectly proportional, they usually

try to patch the rough edges.

5.4 Early Warning Indicators for Coalition Stress

If you want to forecast governing durability, watch indicators that move before cabinet collapse headlines show up.

5.4.1 1) Fragmentation Trend

What to watch: whether the effective number of parliamentary parties is rising across consecutive elections.

Why it matters: more relevant parties means more veto points and more complex coalition contracts.

Worsening signal: coalition talks require three or more medium parties with little ideological overlap.

5.4.2 2) Coalition Ideological Distance

What to watch: policy distance on budget rules, migration, labour-market reform, and EU fiscal integration.

Why it matters: broad coalitions can govern, but only if conflict domains are sequenced and bounded.

Worsening signal: repeated public dissent by coalition partners on high-salience files before first budget passage.

5.4.3 3) Minority-Government Dependency Risk

What to watch: number and volatility of external support parties needed for confidence and supply.

Why it matters: minority cabinets can be durable, but only where support norms are institutionalised.

Worsening signal: support parties begin conditioning routine votes on unrelated policy concessions.

5.4.4 4) Regional-Party Pivot Leverage

What to watch: whether regionally concentrated parties are mathematically pivotal to forming or preserving a majority.

Why it matters: pivotal regional actors can extract asymmetric concessions that strain coalition coherence.

Worsening signal: repeated government crises tied to centre-periphery bargaining files.

5.4.5 5) Seat-Vote Distortion Trend

What to watch: whether the vote-seat gap for governing parties is widening over time.

Why it matters: large distortion can increase legitimacy disputes and sharpen opposition mobilisation.

Worsening signal: governing majority persists with declining vote share and rising disproportionality metrics.

5.4.6 6) Intra-Coalition Policy Incompatibility

What to watch: unresolved conflicts in manifesto commitments that cannot be delayed to committee-level compromise.

Why it matters: some disagreements are symbolic; others are cabinet-breaking.

Worsening signal: coalition leaders escalate disputes in public rather than containing them in bargaining forums.

6 Technical Analysis Tools

7 Notation

The formulae in this primer use the following symbols. Vote and seat shares are percentages on the same scale within each calculation.

Symbol	Meaning	First use
V	Valid votes in a district or election	Droop quota
S	Seats available in that district or election	Droop quota
v_i	Vote share of party i	Gallagher index
s_i	Seat share of party i	Gallagher index
G	Gallagher index of vote-seat disproportionality	Gallagher index

Symbol	Meaning	First use
M	District magnitude, or number of seats in a district	District magnitude comparison

No complex-number convention is needed: this primer contains no imaginary unit.

7.1 The Math Layer That Usually Gets Hidden

Most primers stop at labels like FPTP, STV, or PR. The practical decisions, though, are often made in the allocation formula details. Two systems can both be called "proportional" and still produce noticeably different outcomes.

Three knobs matter a lot:

1. District magnitude (how many seats are allocated in each district).
2. Thresholds (formal legal thresholds and effective thresholds caused by small district size).
3. Allocation formula (D'Hondt, Sainte-Laguë, largest remainder, and so on).

7.1.1 D'Hondt Versus Sainte-Laguë in One Minute

D'Hondt divides party vote totals by 1, 2, 3, … and assigns seats to the highest quotients. Because the divisor starts at 1 and then increments linearly, larger parties tend to keep appearing near the top.

Sainte-Laguë uses odd-number divisors 1, 3, 5, … which smooths that advantage and is usually friendlier to mid-sized parties.

That is why two countries with similar vote shares can still end up with different coalition arithmetic.

7.1.2 Why District Size Quietly Dominates Outcomes

If a district only has 3 to 5 seats, very small parties are effectively locked out even if there is no strict legal threshold. If a district has 15 to 30 seats, seat conversion is much closer to vote shares.

That is one reason the Netherlands (national district) feels so different from Spain (provincial districts), even though both live in the PR family.

7.1.3 Quick Formulas You Actually Use

For STV, the Droop quota is:

$$\text{Quota} = \left\lfloor \frac{V}{S+1} \right\rfloor + 1$$

where V is valid votes and S is seats.

For basic disproportionality checking, analysts often track the Gallagher index:

$$G = \sqrt{\frac{1}{2}\sum_i (v_i - s_i)^2}$$

where v_i is party vote share and s_i is party seat share.

Higher G means more vote-seat distortion.

7.1.4 Worked Example: Gallagher Index in Practice

Suppose an election produces the following national shares:

Party	Vote share v_i	Seat share s_i	Gap $(v_i - s_i)$
A	40	48	-8
B	35	33	2
C	15	12	3
D	10	7	3

Compute:

$$\sum_i (v_i - s_i)^2 = (-8)^2 + 2^2 + 3^2 + 3^2 = 64 + 4 + 9 + 9 = 86$$

Then:

$$G = \sqrt{\frac{1}{2} \cdot 86} = \sqrt{43} \approx 6.56$$

Interpretation in plain English: a value around 6 to 7 signals a noticeable but not extreme vote-seat distortion. In applied work, the trend over time is often more useful than one isolated value.

7.1.5 Worked Example: District Magnitude Sensitivity

Hold votes constant across two district designs:

Party	Vote share
A	38%
B	31%
C	18%
D	13%

Now compare likely outcomes:

Design	Typical seat pattern
Small districts ($M = 4$ to $M = 5$)	A and B over-convert; D frequently excluded
Larger districts ($M = 12$ to $M = 20$)	A and B still lead, but C and D convert more reliably

Why this happens: as district magnitude rises, the effective threshold falls, so smaller parties need less concentrated support to win seats. That one design choice often matters as much as the allocation formula itself.

7.2 Same Votes, Different Parliament: A Worked Comparison

Take this stylised national vote split:

Party	Vote share
A	38%
B	31%
C	18%
D	13%

Now imagine this exact vote distribution is processed by different rule sets.

System type	Typical seat effect
FPTP with geography clustered for A	A can convert 38% vote into an outright seat majority
Two-round majoritarian	A and B dominate runoffs; C and D become kingmakers between rounds
Closed-list PR with D'Hondt and small districts	A and B gain modest bonus, C survives, D under-converts
National PR with low threshold	Seat shares track vote shares much more closely
MMP with compensatory list seats	District distortions are pulled back towards party-vote proportionality

The key practical insight is not that one is morally superior. It is that each design encodes a political theory about governability versus representativeness.

7.3 Coalition Mechanics and Government Durability

Electoral-system discussions often end at seat allocation, but governing risk shows up one step later in coalition formation.

Three recurring patterns across Europe:

1. Manufactured majority systems (or strong winner bonuses) reduce negotiation cost but can produce weak representational legitimacy.
2. Highly proportional systems improve representational legitimacy but increase coalition transaction costs.
3. Hybrid systems often push complexity into post-election bargaining rules and constitutional practice.

What this means for real-world forecasting:

1. The same seat distribution can produce different cabinet stability depending on party-system fragmentation.
2. Pre-election coalitions (Italy pattern) and post-election coalitions (Netherlands pattern) carry different break risks.
3. Minority government viability depends heavily on confidence-and-supply norms, not only electoral math.

7.4 A Practical Analyst Checklist

When you assess a country's electoral system for policy risk, market risk, or geopolitical context, run this checklist:

1. What is the effective threshold in each district, not just the legal threshold?
2. Is the system compensatory (like MMP) or parallel/hybrid without full correction?
3. Are candidate lists open, closed, or mixed?
4. How concentrated is support geographically for the two largest parties?
5. What does the recent gap between vote share and seat share look like?
6. Is government formation path-dependent on two parties, three parties, or many?
7. What institutional backstops exist when coalition talks fail?

If you answer these seven questions, you usually understand the political-system risk far better than by just naming the electoral model.

7.5 Reusable Political-System Risk Scoring Rubric

This rubric is built for repeatable country comparison. Score each dimension from 1 to 5, where 1 is low risk contribution and 5 is high risk contribution.

Dimension	1 (Low Risk)	3 (Medium Risk)	5 (High Risk)
Coalition fragmentation risk	Two-party or stable bloc majority norm	Three-party bargaining common	Four-plus pivotal actors with unstable alignments
Vote-seat distortion risk	Low and stable distortion trend	Moderate distortion with episodic spikes	High or rising distortion undermining legitimacy
Government formation delay risk	Cabinet forms quickly in most cycles	Negotiations often extended	Prolonged deadlock or repeated failed investitures
Minority-dependence risk	Majority cabinets are standard	Minority cabinets occasional	Durable dependence on volatile external support
Regional pivot risk	Regional parties non-pivotal	Regional parties intermittently pivotal	Regional parties routinely hold formation veto leverage

Dimension	1 (Low Risk)	3 (Medium Risk)	5 (High Risk)
Policy-coherence risk	Governing coalition has tight program overlap	Manageable policy divergence	Recurrent high-salience conflict inside governing bloc

7.5.1 Worked Scoring Example: Spain-Style Profile

Illustrative scoring:

1. Coalition fragmentation risk: 4
2. Vote-seat distortion risk: 3
3. Government formation delay risk: 4
4. Minority-dependence risk: 4
5. Regional pivot risk: 5
6. Policy-coherence risk: 3

Total score: 23 out of 30.

Interpretation:

1. Below 12: low formation and durability risk under normal conditions.
2. 12 to 20: manageable but negotiation-sensitive.
3. Above 20: structurally elevated cabinet-formation and stability risk, especially during economic or territorial stress.

How to use this in practice:

1. Track score trend across election cycles, not just one snapshot.
2. Pair score moves with institutional events (investiture failures, budget defeats, coalition exits).
3. Escalate risk flags when score increases by 3 or more points cycle-on-cycle.

8 Conclusion

8.1 Main Takeaway

European electoral systems are not cosmetic variations on one model. They are different institutional choices about representation, governability, and accountability.

The practical way to read the map is to ask three questions at once:

1. How proportionally does the system convert votes into seats?
2. How expensive is coalition formation under that conversion logic?
3. How does domestic government formation translate into EU-level bargaining power?

Viewed that way, the country differences stop looking random. Majoritarian systems buy decisiveness at the cost of proportionality. Proportional systems buy representativeness at the cost of negotiation complexity. Hybrid systems split the difference and push trade-offs into institutional detail.

For analysis, the useful endpoint is not choosing a "best" system. It is identifying which political behaviour each design systematically rewards, and what that implies for policy stability, coalition durability, and EU negotiation outcomes.

9 Further Reading

- International IDEA Electoral System Design Database: comparative descriptions of electoral rules and country-level design choices.
- ACE Electoral Knowledge Network: practical reference material on electoral systems, administration, and comparative terminology.
- European Parliament: national electoral rules: official context for European Parliament elections, kept separate from the domestic systems analysed here.
- Gallagher index overview: Michael Gallagher's explanation of the disproportionality index used in the worked example.
- D'Hondt method: an official worked context for proportional seat allocation and party-list elections.